

Tech Elites, Political Power and Network Diffusion: A Simulation of the PayPal Mafia

Group Assignment for Computational Modelling of Social System Group: 21

Student 1¹, Student 2², and Student 3¹

¹Graz University of Technology, Graz, Austria

²University of Graz, Graz, Austria

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Abstract

This paper investigates whether actors associated with the so called PayPal Mafia occupy structurally advantaged positions within a technology politics influence network and whether they generate broader diffusion effects than comparable elite actors. Drawing on theories of elite networks, homophily, centrality, and threshold based diffusion, we simulated a network of 25 actors, including technology founders, firms, platforms, venture capital actors, government institutions, and the public. Using NetworkX the analysis combines centrality measures with a weighted threshold diffusion model to assess both structural position and simulated influence spread. The results indicate that PayPal affiliated actors, particularly Elon Musk and Peter Thiel, hold highly central and bridging positions within the network. The cascade initiated by the PayPal core reaches 15 of 25 nodes within just two steps. However, the findings also show that this advantage is moderate: the PayPal core outperforms most random elite seed groups but is surpassed by a venture capital and defense tech oriented seed group. The simulation therefore suggests that influence is shaped less by PayPal affiliation itself than by the actual structural placement within the network which links technology and state. The simulation code is available online.¹

¹GitHub repository

1 Introduction

Does the technology we use shape how we think? If yes, who shapes the technologies?

These questions have become increasingly important as digital platforms and large language models move from being simple tools of communication to becoming central infrastructures of information. Systems such as ChatGPT, X and other platform-based technologies increasingly mediate how people search for knowledge, encounter political views, as well as form and influence opinions (Gandini et al., 2025). Instead of solemnly giving information, these systems can generate and also structure them. But there are also other technologies used in the public sectors such as Palantir Gotham a platform, designed for intelligence defense and law enforcement use (Montevirgen, 2026). Technologies like these can even have regulatory implications because they potentially affect vulnerable citizens (Ulbricht and Egbert, 2024).

This gives companies and individuals behind them a quiet but significant form of social and political influence. As Hancock (2025) argues, the risk posed by contemporary tech oligarchy is not only that individual billionaires hold extreme wealth, but that they also control key layers of the information infrastructures on which democratic societies depend.

This concentration of technological and informational power has become a concern in

contemporary politics and sociology. Tech elites increasingly exercise authority across boundaries that traditionally separate markets, infrastructure, media, and also the state. Atal et al. (2026) describe this development as “oligarchic sovereignty”: a structure in which privately controlled technological systems become part of the political architecture. In this context, the owners and founders of major technology companies do not just participate in markets. Rather do they shape the conditions under which information and political narratives spread, as well as how citizens encounter public life. This makes it necessary to ask not only what technologies do, but also who is connected to the technologies that increasingly shape the public.

A particularly relevant case is the so called “PayPal Mafia,” the network of founders and early employees of PayPal after the company’s sale in 2002 (Hoffman and Casnocha, 2013). Individuals of it are part of an ecosystem of companies, investment funds, platforms, as well as political projects. Individuals such as Elon Musk, Peter Thiel, David Sacks, Reid Hoffman and others have become associated with companies and institutions that now occupy central positions in technology, media, artificial intelligence, defense, venture capital, and government (Brehse et al., 2024).

1.1 Background

Past work of Pitti (2004) describes and argues that the group’s shared origin created a durable network advantage, but does not test whether PayPal-affiliated actors actually have structurally advantaged positions or whether they are especially effective at spreading influence through the technology political network. Research on Silicon Valley shows its robust complex system of innovation which is supported by social networks of interdependent economic agents in which the Venture Capital firms function specifically (Ferrary and Granovetter (2009)).

Other research on the business elite shows that the ties people form early on their careers leave a lasting impact, so much that well placed actors keep outperforming others who are just

as talented but less connected (Uzzi et al., 2016). One reason this happens is homophily, the tendency for similar individuals to connect to one another, which produces and reinforces structures that channel influence across the connections that already exist (McPherson et al., 2001). Eigenvector based measures, assess structural bias in how information and influence are aggregated across a network (Bienenstock and Bonacich, 2022). A very centralized network is one where a few nodes decide a lot about what the whole group ends up paying attention to. At the largest scale, Atal et al. (2026) argue that technology elites now reach between markets, infrastructure and the state, to the point where privately owned systems and platforms start to shape global order itself.

Position in a network is one thing, but the way influence actually diffuses through it is another. Granovetter (1978) showed that collective behaviour depends not only on what individuals want but on thresholds, of how many others have to act before a given person joins in. Granovetter (1978)’s threshold model established that collective outcomes depend not only on individual predispositions but also on the distribution of thresholds and the order in which actors are exposed to active others.

Watts (2002) extended this logic to networks, showing that global cascades occur only under specific structural conditions, while Kempe et al. (2003) then asked which starting nodes spread influence the furthest, which means that the choice of where a cascade begins can matter just as much as the shape of the network. Unicom et al. (2018) added that the weight of the ties matters too, since the strength of a connection decides whether the influence adding up on a node is enough to push it over its threshold. In total this implies that a small set of highly central and strongly tied actors can seed disproportionately large cascades. Although the PayPal phenomenon has been described it has not been modelled yet. Furthermore were diffusion and centralization frameworks rarely been applied to a concrete technology and political elite. This paper tries to explore this gap.

The research question we pose therefore is: whether the actors tied to the PayPal network sit in structurally advantages positions inside

a technology and politics influence network, and whether they set off a wider spread of influence comparable group of randomly chosen elite actors under a weighted threshold model. To explore this question we simulate a a weighted threshold diffusion based on simulated network.

2 Methodology

2.1 Building the network

The model is implemented in Python using the NetworkX library. The network is a directed graph of 25 nodes and 42 edges.

Nodes represent heterogeneous actors of four types: persons (e.g. Elon Musk, Peter Thiel, Donald Trump), organisations, platforms or venture capital firms (e.g. PayPal, Twitter/X, Founders Fund, OpenAI), and institutions (the U.S. government, the defence system, and “the Public”). Each node is also assigned to one of nine subgroups, such as paypal mafia, tech, governmentpolitics, AI infrastructure, investmentfirm and more. These serve both as visual categories, as well as filters for evaluating whether cascades reach governmental or public actors. Directed edges encode relations such as founder/executive ties, investment links, political support, government contracting or information flows. Each carry a weight between 0- 1 to showcase relationship strength.

Three node-level parameters drive the model.

- Power (0–1) represents an actor’s capacity to influence others.
- Threshold, defined as the number or proportion of others who must make one decision before a given actor is activated.
- Infrastructure power, which captures the degree to which a node functions as a platform, surveillance, or AI system of broad societal reach.

The values were formulated by us rather than extracted from a dataset as these concepts are difficult to quantify. For example are Elon Musk, Donald Trump and the U.S. government each assigned with the maximum power of 1.00,

while ChatGPT receives the maximum infrastructure power. This is therefore a synthetic, theory-driven network, which is if further addressed in the Limitations.

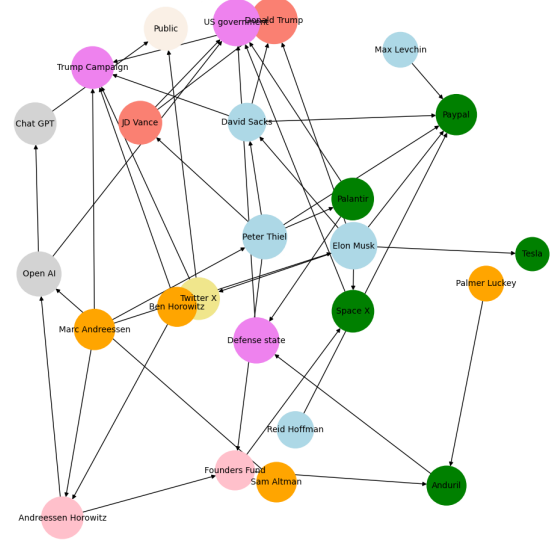


Figure 1: People and organizations of tech-political network

2.2 Centrality measures

To assess structural position of where each actor sits, the network is first turned into an undirected version. Because betweenness and closeness require a notion of distance, every edge is given a distance equal to one divided by its weight (distance = $1/\text{weight}$). A stronger tie then counts as a shorter path, which fits the weighted view of contagion by Unicomb et al. (2018).

Four standard measures are computed (Bienenstock and Bonacich (2022)): degree centrality (direct connectivity), betweenness centrality (brokerage across shortest weighted paths), eigenvector centrality (connection to other well connected nodes, computed with edge weights) and closeness centrality (overall proximity to the network). Reporting all four allows the analysis to distinguish actors who are just well connected from those who occupy genuine bridging or influential positions.

2.3 Weighted threshold diffusion

Influence spread is modelled with a weighted threshold diffusion process that combines the threshold logic of Granovetter (1978) and Watts (2002) with the weighted-influence and seed-selection concerns of Unicomb et al. (2018) and Kempe et al. (2003). At each step, an inactive node aggregates influence from its directed predecessors. For a neighbour, the contribution is the edge weight multiplied by an influence capacity equal to $(\text{power} + 0.5 \times \text{infrastructure power})$. The 0.5 coefficient is the model's infrastructure coefficient. The node computes an adoption ratio equal to the active predecessors contribution divided by the total contribution of all predecessors. It activates when this ratio meets or exceeds its threshold.

- *Active Influence* = $\text{edge weight} \times (\text{power} + 0.5 \times \text{infrastructure power})$
- *Total possible influence*: $\text{total influence} = \text{edge weight} \times (\text{power} + 0.5 \times \text{infrastructure power})$
- *Node adopts when*:

$$\frac{\text{active influence}}{\text{total influence}} \geq \text{threshold}$$

The process iterates until no further node activates or 20 step limit is reached. This is a linear threshold style with weighted, with attribute influence. Infrastructure rich nodes such as ChatGPT or state institutions therefore propagate influence more strongly than ordinary actors. Afterwards four analyses are done. The first starts the spread from the three core seeds the PayPal actors Musk, Thiel and Sacks, who are treated as already active. The second compares seven scenarios with different starting groups, such as the PayPal core, the Musk and Thiel ecosystems, the AI infrastructures, platforms and public group, venture capital and defense group, as well as a government group. For this we recorded how many nodes end up active and whether the government and the public nodes are reached. The third is a random baseline that runs the same spread 1,000 times from random groups of three people, which gives us something to compare the PayPal result against.

A final sensitivity tests showcases how sensitive the model is, by rescaling every threshold by 0.75, 1.0 and 1.25 and by setting the infrastructure coefficient to 0.0, 0.5 and 1.0. A fixed random seed of 67 keeps the runs reproducible.

3 Results

3.1 Centrality and structural advantage

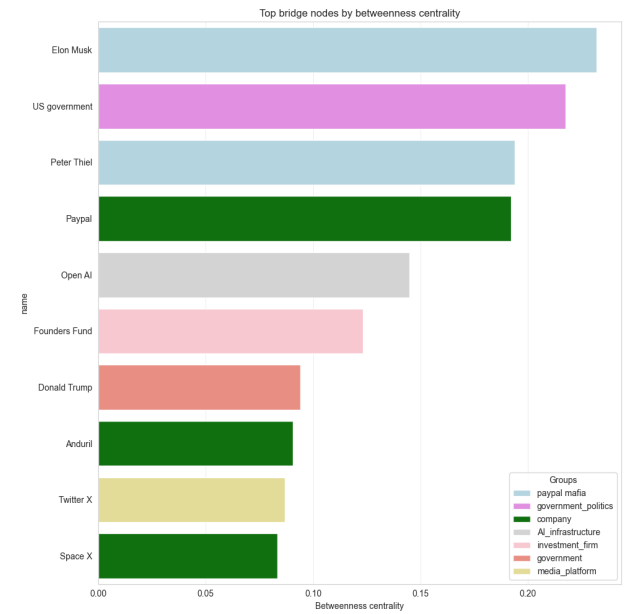


Figure 2: The ten nodes with the highest betweenness, coloured by group. PayPal actors, shown in light blue and government actors hold leading bridge positions

The centrality analysis (Figure 2) shows that the most structurally advantaged positions are shared between PayPal affiliated actors and government institutions rather than being a monopol of either side.

Actor (group)	Betweenness	Degree	Eigenvector	Closeness	Power
Elon Musk (PayPal)	.232	.292	.366	.340	1.00
US government (gov.)	.217	.250	.306	.330	1.00
Peter Thiel (PayPal)	.194	.250	.330	.339	0.90
PayPal (company)	.192	.208	.306	.321	0.75
OpenAI (AI infra.)	.145	.167	.067	.245	0.90
Founders Fund (VC)	.123	.167	.153	.302	0.70
Donald Trump (gov.)	.094	.208	.370	.344	1.00
Anduril (company)	.091	.125	.067	.242	0.70
Twitter/X (platform)	.087	.125	.144	.282	0.80
SpaceX (company)	.083	.125	.201	.320	0.80

Figure 3: Centrality scores for the ten nodes with the highest betweenness

Figure 3 shows that Elon Musk has the highest betweenness centrality (.232) and the highest degree (.292), which makes him the network's main bridge. Right behind him come the US government at .217 and Peter Thiel (.194), with the PayPal company fourth (.192). On the eigenvector measure, which can be read as influence over how information is pooled (bienenstock2022eigenvector), Donald Trump comes first (.370), just ahead of Musk (.366), Thiel (.330) and Sacks at (.328) while the US government and PayPal tie are lower (both at .306). Closeness centrality tells a similar story, with Trump at .344, Musk at .340 and Thiel at .339. Across every measure, three PayPal actors and the PayPal company keep showing up near the top, but the main government nodes do as well. The showcases the ties of the actors are and how that reaches across technology and the state at the same time.

3.2 Starting from the PayPal core

Starting the spread from Musk, Thiel and Sacks sets off a fast and wide cascade. From the three seeds the process switches on 11 nodes at step 1 and 15 of the 25 nodes by step 2, after which it stops. The first wave pulls in the immediate business ties, PayPal, Founders Fund, Palantir, SpaceX, Tesla and Twitter/X, along with two political actors J.D. Vance and Donald Trump. The second wave reaches Anduril, the Trump Campaign, the US government and the defense state. In other words, the influence moves out of the technology world and into government in just two steps (Figure 4 and Figure 5). Several nodes switch on with their ratio well past the threshold. Palantir, Tesla, Twitter/X and Vance each reach a ratio of 1.0, which reflects how dense and strongly weighted the ties among the PayPal linked nodes are.

3.3 Comparing different starting groups

Comparing seed sets (Figure 6 and 7) showcase differences in spreading. Although the PayPal core is one of the most effective seeds, activating 15 nodes and reaching five governmental nodes including the U.S. government, the

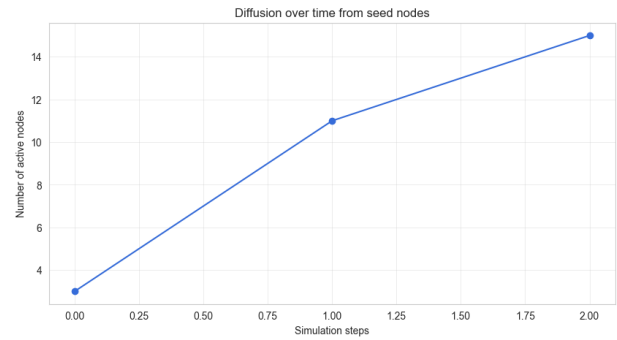


Figure 4: How many nodes are active at each step when the spread starts from the PayPal core. The cascade levels off after two steps at 15 of 25 nodes.

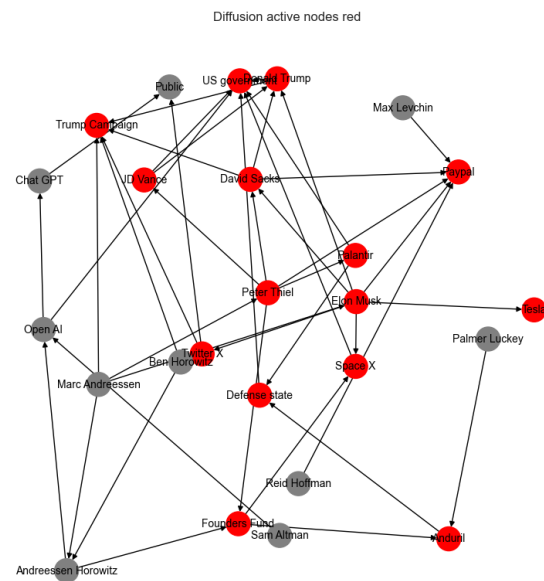


Figure 5: The 25 node technology and politics network. Red nodes are the ones that switch on when the spread is started from the three core PayPal actors, grey nodes stay off.

venture capital/defense tech seeds (Andreessen, Horowitz, Luckey) diffuse furthest of all, activating 19 nodes. The Thiel ecosystem reaches 10 nodes, while platform, Musk, AI and government seeds spread less widely. Furthermore, the AI infrastructure and government only seeds produce no cascade (final active count equal to the three seeds, zero additional steps).

Despite the high values of OpenAI, ChatGPT, and the state, these nodes occupy positions in the simulated network from which influence does not propagate under the models directed structure as they do not reflect ties but rather influence on society itself which is not part of the simulated network. Even though OpenAI,

ChatGPT and the state carry very high power and infrastructure values within the network the directions of the edges leave them in places from which influence simply doesn't flow. It is the position of the starting group, rather than the power that drives the spread, which also is reflected by the seed selection problem described by Kempe et al. (2003).

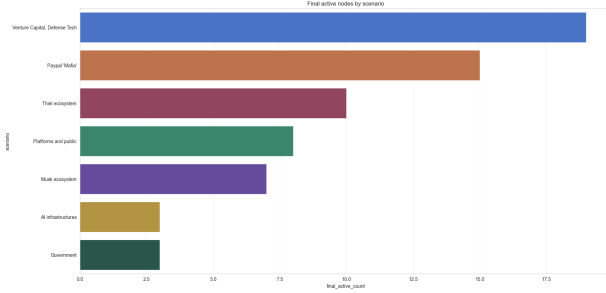


Figure 6: Final number of active nodes for each starting group. The venture capital and defense group spreads the furthest, with the PayPal core in second place.

Seed scenario	Final active	Steps	Gov. nodes reached	US gov. reached
VC and Defence Tech	19	4	5	Yes
PayPal core	15	2	5	Yes
Thiel ecosystem	10	3	5	Yes
Platforms and public	8	3	2	No
Musk ecosystem	7	3	2	No
AI infrastructures	3	0	0	No
Government	3	0	3	No

Figure 7: Spread outcomes for each starting group.

3.4 Random baseline comparison

Compared with the 1,000 random groups of three people, the PayPal cascade of 15 nodes sits above the random average of about 11.6 nodes. It is therefore in the upper middle of the spread rather than far out at the edge (Figure 8). The PayPal group beats 63.3 percent of the random groups outright and matches or beats 66.7 percent of them. Across the random runs the US government is reached about 51 percent of the time, while the Public is reached only about 11 percent of the time, which showcases that capturing government is fairly easy in this network while reaching the wider public is much harder. So the PayPal advantage is real but modest in

this simulation. It does better than most random elite three seeds, yet a lot of random groups match or beat it and at least one carefully chosen group does better.

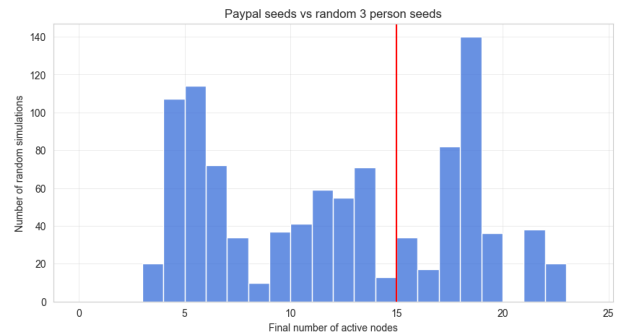


Figure 8: How big the cascade gets across 1,000 random groups of three people, with the PayPal result marked by the red line. The PayPal group beats 63.3 percent of the random groups.

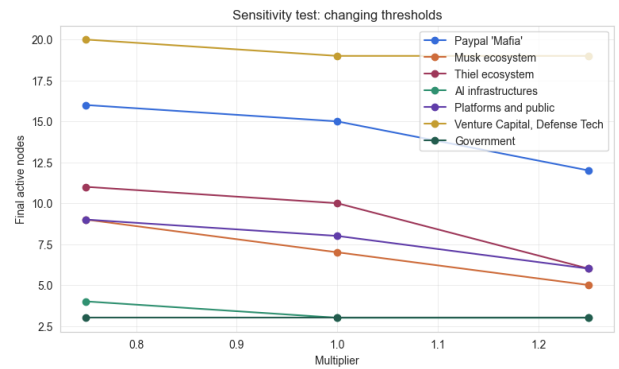


Figure 9: Change of thresholds.

3.5 Sensitivity

The model reacts to the threshold (Figure 9) but barely notices the infrastructure coefficient. Lowering every threshold by 25 percent makes the cascades slightly larger, the PayPal core rises from 15 to 16 and the Musk ecosystem from 7 to 9. Raising every threshold by 25 percent shrinks them, so the PayPal core falls to 12 and the Thiel ecosystem from 10 to 6. This is the threshold dependence we would expect described by Granovetter (1978) and Watts (2002). The infrastructure coefficient behaves slightly different. Setting it to 0.0, 0.5 or 1.0 leaves every scenarios final cascade size unchanged. Because the infrastructure term shows up in both the top and the bottom of the adoption ratio, rescaling it

does not change which nodes cross their thresholds in this particular network. That is an important null result, that we further elaborate on.

4 Discussion

The model of the simulation aligns with the central claims done by previous literature, that the PayPal figures do sit in strong positions (Uzzi et al., 2016, Pitti (2004)). Elon Musk is positioned as the main bridge, and Thiel, Sacks and the PayPal company cluster are at the top of the centrality rankings done in the simulation. The fast two step cascade that runs from the PayPal core into government and defense nodes is a small and simplified version of the tactical move from Silicon Valley to Washington that Pitti (2004) describes. Showcasing how technology elites become more interwoven into the government and the general united state as described by 2026. The political views these actors hold might explain the subtle "vibe shift" experience in the US, as political actors such as JD Vance and Donald Trump have had campaigns partially funded by Tech Actors (Peter Thiel).

At the same time the strongest positions in the model are not held by the technology cohort alone. Trump leads on eigenvector and closeness centrality, as well as the US government which keeps turning up among the most central nodes. The way eigenvector centrality piles up in a handful of mixed technology and government nodes is a sign of structural bias in how influence is pooled in the network simulation (Bienenstock and Bonacich, 2022). The bias often favours an elite that is part technology and part politics, not just technology. The scenario and baseline results show that that PayPal is not to be seen as that unique. The venture capital and defence group spreads further. Furthermore does the PayPal group beat only about 63 percent of random elite trios. The edge is there but modest, it also stems more from good positioning than from anything distinct about "PayPal Mafia" as such. That fits Kempe et al. (2003), that explain that the spread depends on where a cascade is seeded, as well as Watts (2002), that states that cascades depend on structural conditions rather than on the fame of any single actor. The homophily built into the network

also explain the speed of the cascade. The PayPal linked nodes are joined by dense, strongly weighted ties, with nodes that are similar and connected leading to each others crossing of thresholds fastly. On the other hand the same dense structure traps influence inside the cluster. Groups that start outside the dense core, like the AI infrastructures or the government only group, fail to spread at all in the simulation. So homophily shows up both ways. All together, the model supports the qualitative literature's emphasis on elite networks and cross domain influence (politics and technology). Although the model also shows that the influence of a network is not based on inherent power per se but rather simply on its structure and placement.

5 Limitations

Our project shows how influence could spread in a network of tech CEOs, companies and political actors, but the model has several important limitations. Many of them come from the fact that we built the network by hand and chose the parameters ourselves, without using a large empirical dataset. We are going to discuss the most important points below.

5.1 The network is built by hand and is incomplete

We selected the nodes (people, companies and institutions) based on our own research of the "PayPal Mafia" and the current US tech-political landscape. This means that the network only reflects a small part of reality. Other important actors, such as Microsoft, Google, Meta, Jeff Bezos with its Amazon or non-US tech elites, are not included. A different selection of nodes would probably change the results. The network should therefore be seen as one possible representation, not as the full picture.

5.2 The network is static

The graph represents a single snapshot in time. In reality, relationships between people and companies change. Alliances can form, weaken

or even break. For instance does the public conflict between Elon Musk and Donald Trump in 2025 show that political alignments are not stable. Our model cannot capture these changes over time. We are limited here with the current situation.

5.3 The edge weights are not measured empirically

We assigned the weights of the edges (for example 0.90 for "founder", 0.45 for "vcecosystem") based on our own intuition about how strong a relationship is. We did not use empirical sources such as the number of co-investments, board memberships or news co-mentions. Different weights would lead to different cascades, so the exact numerical results should not be over interpreted.

5.4 Influence is not directly measurable.

Concepts such as "power", "threshold" or "infrastructural importance" cannot be observed directly in the real world. There is no dataset that says "Elon Musk has a power score of 1.00". We therefore had to translate these abstract sociological concepts into numerical values between 0 and 1 ourselves, based on plausible reasoning. This is a general limitation of computational modelling of social systems: many of the most interesting variables are latent and have to be approximated.

5.5 Limited availability of empirical data on elite networks.

There is no public, complete dataset that lists all the relevant relationships between tech CEOs, their companies, investors, and political actors. Information about who invests in whom, who advises whom, or who is politically aligned with whom is spread across news articles, interviews, and partial databases such as LittleSis or Crunchbase. Because of this, we had to build the network by hand, based on publicly known facts. This is a structural limitation of working on elite influence: the people we study often

have an interest in keeping their relationships informal or non-public.

5.6 Social influence is more complex than any model can capture.

Real influence between people and institutions includes emotions, trust, media framing, personal history, financial dependencies, ideology, and many other factors. A simulation always has to reduce this complexity to a small number of mechanisms (in our case — > weighted neighbors and a threshold). This simplification is necessary to make the model understandable and computable, but it means that the simulation can only represent one specific aspect of influence and not the full social reality.

5.7 Summary of Limitations

The main limitations of our project was not coding errors or wrong assumptions, but the overall structural limitations of gathering data of elite influence with a network simulation. Because data of elite relationships is mostly incomplete and hardly accessible for the public (key variables like power, influence, threshold are not directly observable). The simulation results cannot be validated against a clear real world data truth base. Our simulation should therefore be understood as a theoretical and exploratory tool that makes assumptions.

6 Conclusion

The research question of this paper was whether actors connected to the PayPal network sit in structurally advantaged positions inside a technology and politics influence network and whether they spread influence further than a comparable group of randomly chosen elite actors.

For the first question the answer based on our simulation is yes but with some restrictions. The centrality analysis shows that Elon Musk has the highest betweenness and degree centrality of the whole network and Peter Thiel, David Sacks and the PayPal company also rank among the top nodes on every measure. So the PayPal actors do hold strong bridging and connecting positions. However the same top positions are also occupied by Donald Trump and the US government. Trump even leads on eigenvector and closeness centrality. This means the structural advantage in our model is not held by the tech actors alone but is shared with central political actors.

For the second question the result is more careful. When we start the cascade from the three PayPal seeds (Musk, Thiel and Sacks) the influence reaches 15 of 25 nodes in only two steps including government and defense nodes. Compared to 1000 random groups of three persons the PayPal group beats about 63 percent of them and matches or beats about 67 percent. So the PayPal seeds do spread influence further than the average random elite group but the advantage is moderate rather than singular. The scenario comparison even shows that a different group (the venture capital and defense tech actors) reaches 19 nodes which is more than the PayPal core itself. This tells us that the spread depends more on the structural position of the starting group than on the PayPal origin itself.

The sensitivity analysis adds another point to the result. The cascade size reacts as expected when we change the thresholds but the infrastructure coefficient (0.0 0.5 or 1.0) does not change any final cascade size. Since this term appears in both the numerator and the denominator of the adoption ratio it cancels out for this network. We see this as a useful finding because it pushed us to look at our own model more crit-

ically and to see that not every parameter we added actually does work.

Overall the simulation supports the qualitative claim from the literature that the PayPal network sits in a strong position between technology and politics but it does not show that they are uniquely powerful. The cascade behaviour is driven by structural position and dense ties between similar actors not by a "PayPal Mafia" identity on its own. The model also shows the value and the limits of using a simulation for this kind of question. A formal model forces us to write down our assumptions and to test them but it can also only be as good as the data and the parameters that we put in.

So coming back to the questions we started with. Yes the technology we use can shape how we think and yes the people behind these technologies do hold structurally strong positions in our simulated network. But the answer to "who shapes the technologies" is not a single closed group like the PayPal Mafia. It is a wider mix of technology actors and political institutions whose influence depends on where they sit in the network and how strongly they are connected to the rest.

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